A DATA-DRIVEN STORY • TRUSTMRR, 1,000 STARTUPS • FROZEN 30 JUL 2026

What Makes a Successful Startup?

Lessons From 1,000 Startups

An executive briefing on where startup revenue really comes from, what predicts it, and what founders and investors should do about it.

01 • THE OBJECTIVE

1,000 Startups, One Question: What Actually Drives Success?

This is a long-tail market — a handful of startups generate most of the revenue, while the typical startup earns just $282 a month.

1,000
Live startups tracked on TrustMRR, spanning 29 categories

65
Countries represented, led by the US, France and India

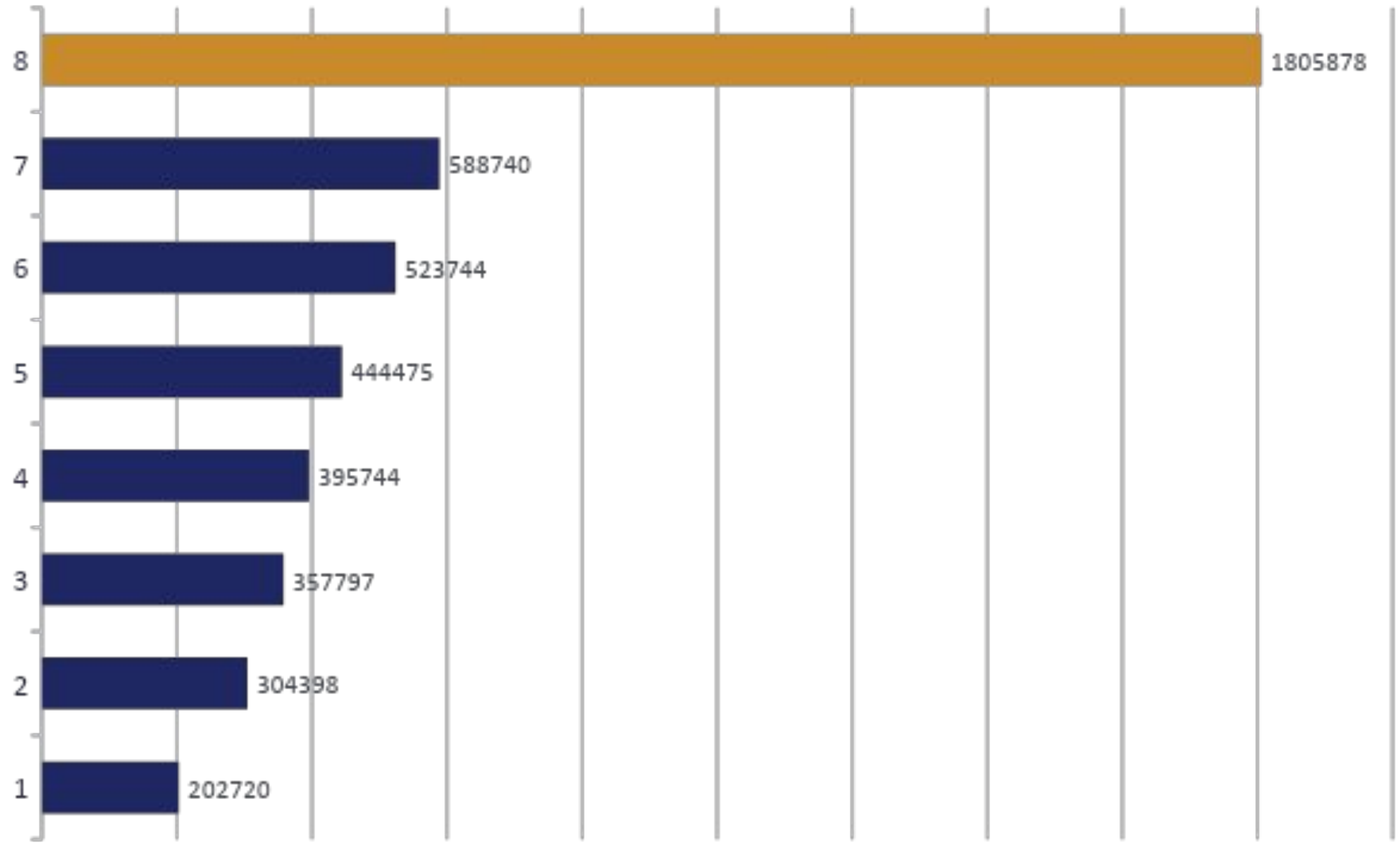
$334M
Combined all-time revenue generated across the dataset

48x
Gap between average ($13,472) and typical ($282) monthly revenue per startup

The gap between average and typical revenue is the story of this entire deck. A small number of startups pull the average far above what most founders actually experience — so the real question isn't “what's the average startup worth,” it's “what separates the few that break away from the pack.” That's what we investigate next.

Three Categories Capture Half the Revenue

AI, SaaS and Education hold just 40% of categorized startups but generate 50% of category-level revenue.



REVENUE SHARE OF TOP 3

49.8%

of all category-tagged monthly revenue comes from AI, SaaS and Education alone.

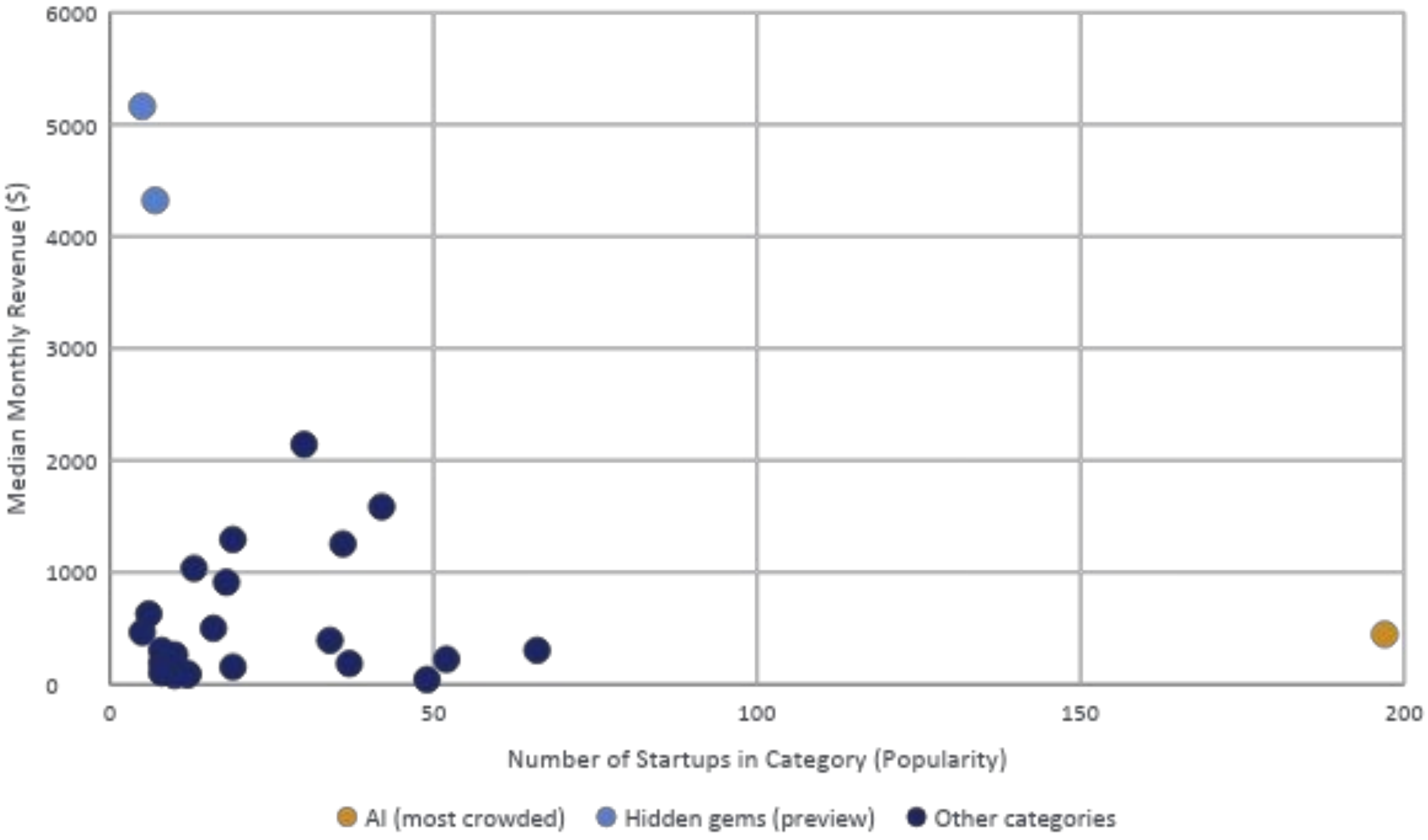
AI SHARE OF REVENUE

30.8%

from 27% of categorized startups — roughly proportional, not the outsized share the hype implies.

The Most Crowded Category Isn't the Most Profitable One

AI draws 39x more startups than Customer Support, yet the typical Customer Support startup earns 11.6x more per month.



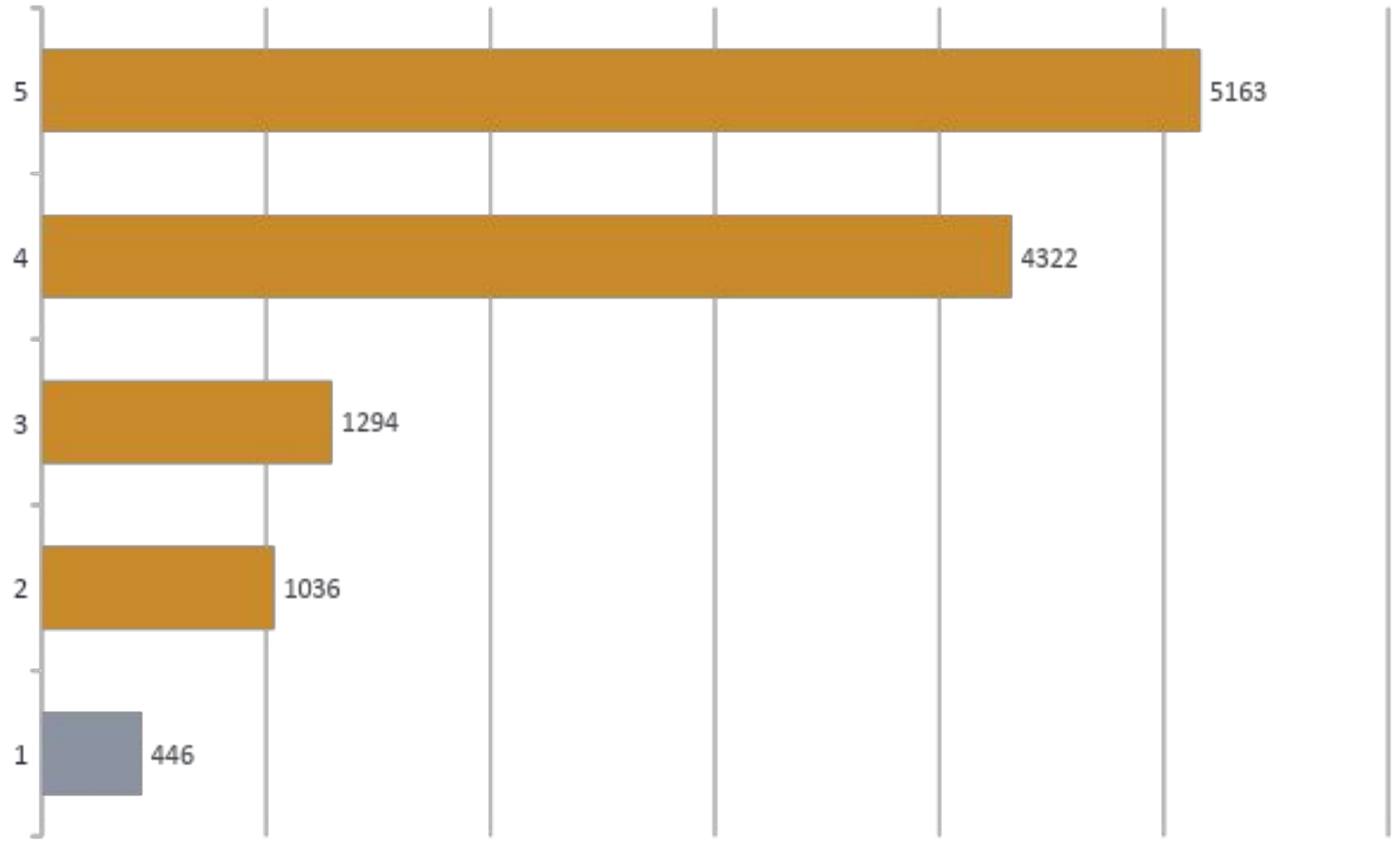
READING THE CHART

Far right, low: AI (197 startups) is the most crowded category, but its median startup earns only $446/month.

Far left, high: Customer Support and Marketplace have almost no competition, yet post the richest typical revenue in the dataset — a preview of Slide 5.

The Real Opportunity Is Hiding in Plain Sight

Customer Support and Marketplace startups earn 9–12x AI's typical revenue with a fraction of the competition.



WHY THESE CATEGORIES WIN

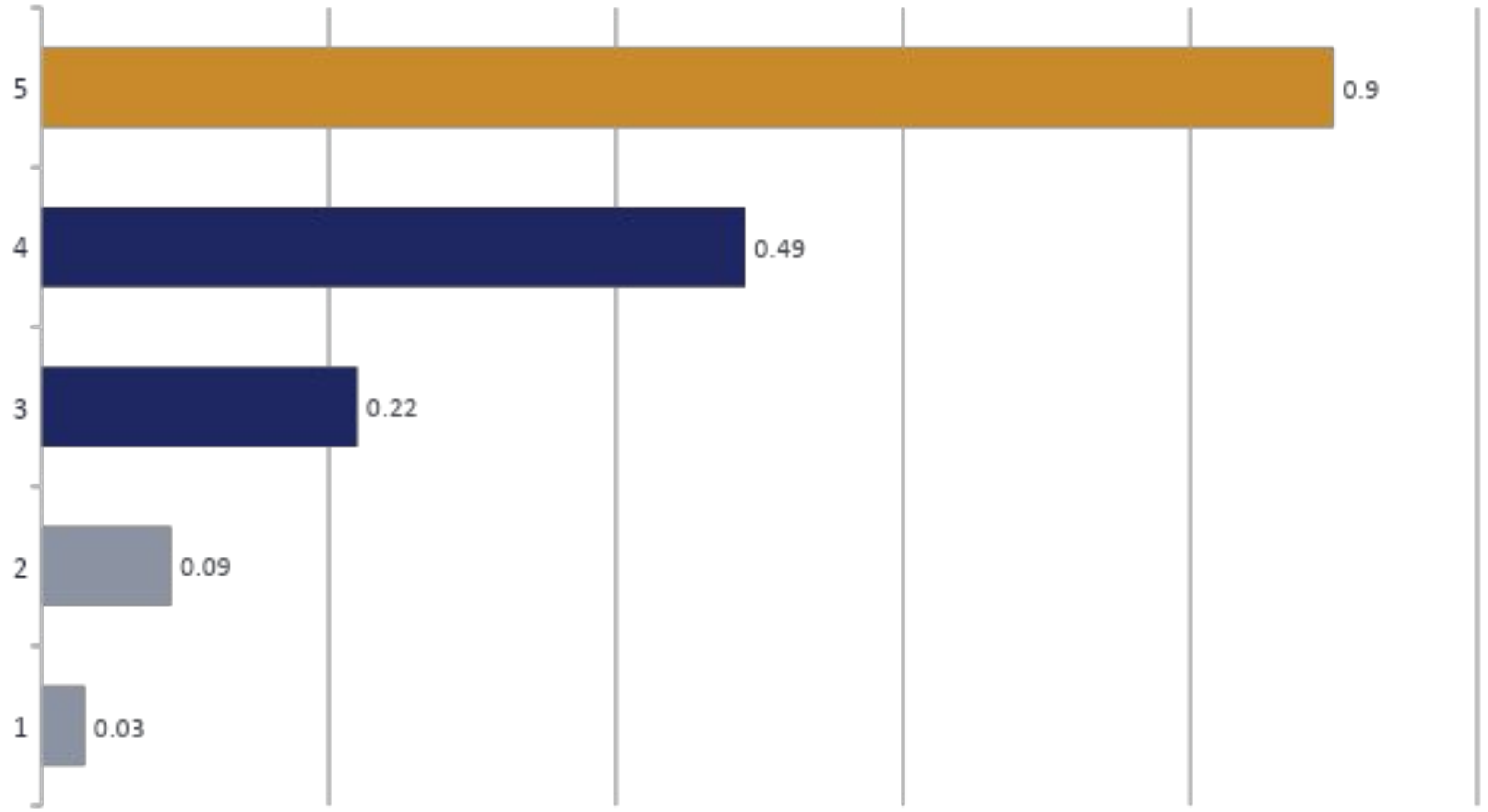
Customer Support startups sell to B2B buyers at high price points with just 5 startups splitting the category.

Marketplace startups monetize transactions, not attention — 7 startups, median $4,322/month.

Less noise, less competition, more durable revenue per player.

Subscribers Predict Revenue — Growth Headlines Don't

Active subscriptions predict MRR ten times more reliably than this month's revenue growth rate.



METHOD

Spearman rank correlation of each metric against current monthly recurring revenue, across all 1,000 startups (ρ ranges from 0 = no relationship to 1 = perfect).

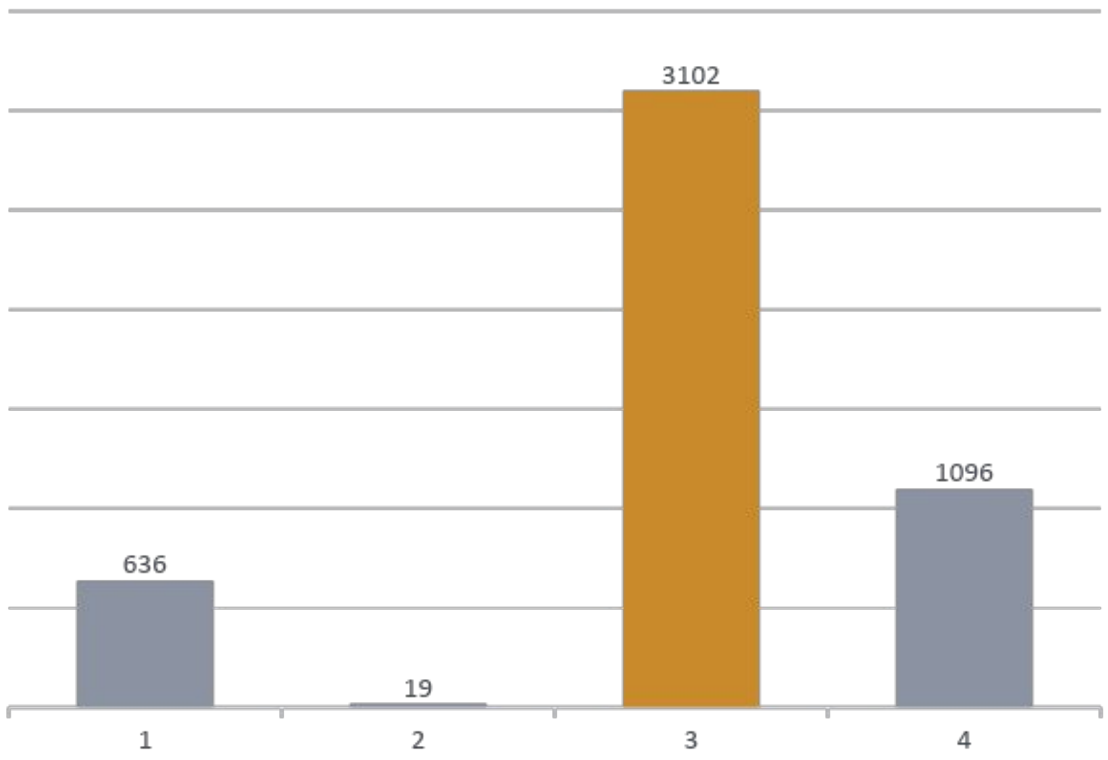
THE TAKEAWAY

Durable fundamentals — subscribers, brand authority — explain revenue. Short-term growth rates barely do.

Growth Rate Is a Weak Signal — Subscriber Depth Isn't

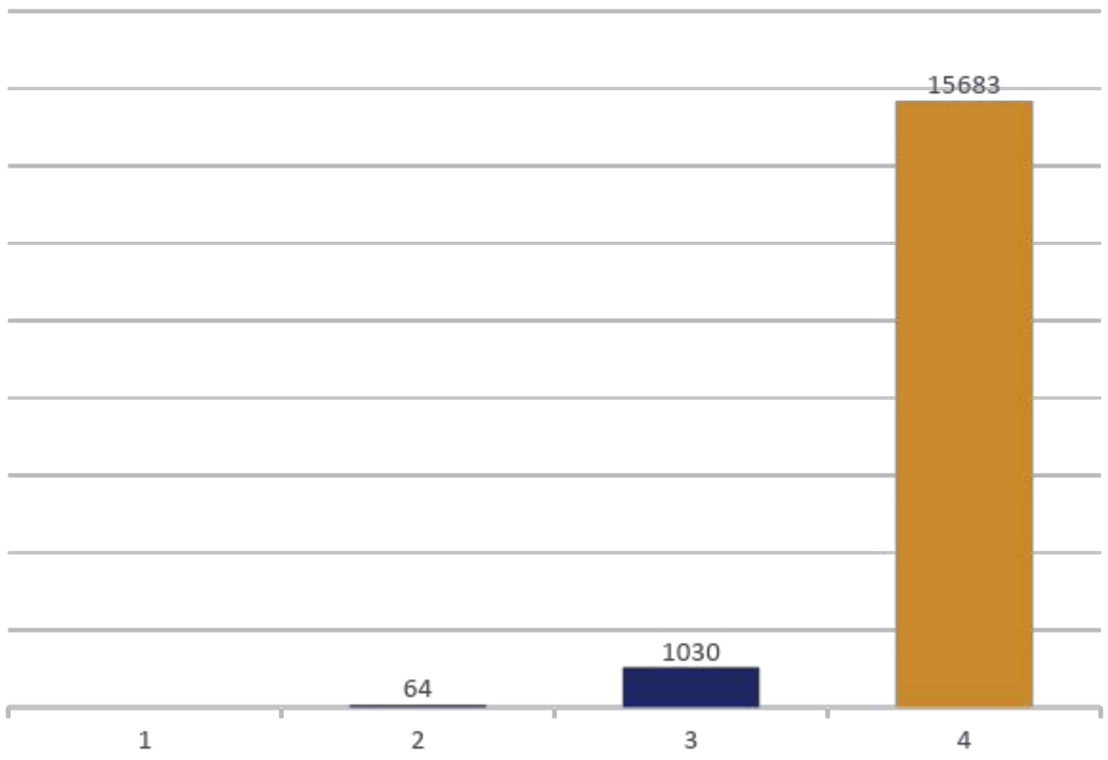
Median MRR barely moves across growth quartiles, but climbs from $0 to nearly $16,000 across subscriber quartiles.

BY 30-DAY GROWTH QUARTILE



No clean trend — the highest typical revenue sits with modest, steady growers (Q3), not the flashiest gainers.

BY ACTIVE-SUBSCRIBER QUARTILE



A clean staircase — median revenue climbs steadily and dramatically with subscriber depth.

Four Patterns That Challenge Common Assumptions

Growth headlines, social followings and free tiers are weaker signals of success than they appear.

VANITY GROWTH

+1,227% growth — on $1,460

HotelHero.ai posted the dataset's steepest 30-day MRR growth. But that's a spike off a tiny base — triple-digit % growth often signals a small business, not a breakout.

SUBSCRIBERS > FOLLOWERS

$3.57M MRR, 15,595 followers

Stan runs $3.57M in monthly recurring revenue from 101,590 active subscriptions — despite a modest social following and a -7.6% revenue dip this month.

FREE ISN'T FREE MONEY

Freemium: $159 median MRR

Startups offering a free tier post a $159 median MRR — about a fifth of the $751 median for paid-only peers.

GROWTH ≠ VALUE

Growth vs. multiple: −0.17

30-day growth and sale valuation multiple are slightly negatively correlated — buyers price durability, not this month's spike.

Three Moves, Backed by the Data

Build for depth, look past the hype, and price on durability — not this month's headline number.

01

FOR FOUNDERS

Build depth, not spikes

Active subscriptions predict MRR far more reliably (ρ=0.90) than 30-day growth (ρ=0.09). Invest in retention and expansion over growth-hacking a headline percentage.

02

FOR FOUNDERS

Look past the AI gold rush

AI hosts 27% of startups, yet the typical player earns just $446/month — below Marketing, Education, Customer Support and Analytics. Under-crowded categories offer stronger typical economics.

03

FOR INVESTORS

Price on durability signals

Subscriber base and domain authority track revenue far better than growth rate or listed multiples. Weight diligence toward fundamentals, not this month's headline number.

THE TAKEAWAY

Success isn't the fastest growth story — it's the most durable one.

Across 1,000 startups, subscriber depth and brand authority explain revenue far better than this month's growth headline, category hype, or social following.

Data: TrustMRR — 1,000-startup dataset, frozen 30 Jul 2026

Thank you — questions welcome.